

On the History of the Middle Persian Nominal Inflection

ALBERTO CANTERA, Salamanca

In two independent studies NICHOLAS SIMS-WILLIAMS (1981) and PRODS O. SKJÆRVØ (1983) put an end to a long discussion regarding the distinction between direct and oblique in the nominal inflection of Middle Persian. SIMS-WILLIAMS demonstrated that in Manichaean Middle Persian the function of the *r*-forms of the kinship nouns is different from that of the *r*-less forms and that the *r*-forms play the role of an oblique singular. The same is true for inscriptional Middle Persian and for the Middle Persian of the Psalms, as shown by P. O. SKJÆRVØ. Later I argued that the same distribution is to be found in the oldest writings of Book Pahlavi, i.e. in some of the Pahlavi translations of the Avesta (CANTERA 1999).

Although the function of the *r*-forms of the kinship nouns has been established beyond all reasonable doubt, several problems remain to be solved. First, there is a formal problem: what is the protoform of the oblique in *r*? As with the personal pronouns, we would expect the oblique to continue the old genitive singular, but the form is not the expected one. Second, although the distribution between direct and oblique seems clear, their respective use as direct object is inconsistent. Third, at the time of the oldest attestations, such functional distinction is confined to the agent nouns. However, the existence of “doublettes”¹ indicates that the same distinction had formerly also been in use for other stems. Consequently, the question arises as to which one, the direct or the oblique, is continued in the only surviving form.

In this contribution in honour of N. SIMS-WILLIAMS, I hope to answer some of these questions in the context of an analysis of Middle Persian nominal stem formation, leaving aside nominal endings which had disappeared. Special attention will be given to the doublettes which could have developed from the old forms of the direct and oblique. I hope to demonstrate that the way nouns developed from Old to Middle Persian depended strongly on their respective stems, and more precisely on the number of syllables, equal or different, of the nominative and accusative forms in each inflection. According to this distinction two different subsystems evolved in an earlier phase of Middle Persian nominal inflection. From the typological point of view, the existence of two

1 I use the term doublette for two different lexemes that historically continue different inflection forms of the same word, e.g. Spanish *virto* < lat. *uirtus* and *virtud* < **uirtutem*.

different subsystems depending on the stem formation could be compared with the different subsystems that developed in the Sogdian nominal inflection: one for the light and another for the heavy stems.

Classification of the nouns in Middle Persian into two different flexive classes was thus based primarily on the isosyllabicity, or the lack of it, of the Old Iranian nominative and accusative. The nouns with isosyllabic nominative and accusative in Old Iranian, like

– **katakah* > **kadagi* > *kadag*

– **katakam* > **kadagu* > *kadag*

include the thematic stems, the *ā*-stems, most of the *i*- and *u*-stems and, *per definitionem*, all neuters.²

Let us call “imparisyllabic” all nouns whose accusative has one syllable more than their respective nominative. To this group belong the consonant stems and the *i*- and *u*-stems with presuffixal full or long grade in the nominative and with a secondary accusative with the syllabic structure *-āUam*³, e.g.:

– **br̥jant-s* > **br̥jāq* > *burz*

**br̥jantam* > **bulandu* > *buland*

– **ḥHūā*

**ḥHūānam* > **urwānu* > *urwān*

– **naćāuš*

**naćāuam* > *nasāuu* > *nasāy*

Isosyllabic nouns

In the case of the isosyllabic nouns, the doublettes derived from the direct and oblique respectively continue two different protoforms: 1. the old genitive with a bisyllabic *-ahīa* ending, and 2. another form with a monosyllabic ending, which theoretically could be any form of the singular except the genitive, but which is most likely the nominative or the accusative. It is not always easy to determine whether a form continues the old genitive or the old nominative-accusative, but the accent rules and the related rules of syncope allow us in certain fortunate cases to determine the actual protoform.

According to KLINGENSCHMITT (2000, p. 210), the conditions for a syncope are the following: a short unaccented paenultima is syncopated when it stands between a non-obstruent and an occlusive consonant or between two identical occlusive consonants. Consequently, forms like *zard* < **jāritah/-am* or *pahn* < **pādanah/-am* must be derived from the nominative-accusative and not from

2 This list is not exhaustive. Other nouns could be added, for example, *H*-stems like nom. **pantāh₂-s*, acc. *pantāh₂-m*, gen. *path₂ah*. The rule is that all nouns with isosyllabic nominative and accusative in Old Iranian belong to this group.

3 The regular form of the accusative of such stems is nevertheless *-*ām* (CANTERA 2007).

the genitive, as the conditions for the syncope are not given in the latter case (**farítahja* > ***zarid*).

When the conditions for a syncope are given, the doublettes usually have one syncopated form (the old nominative-accusative) and another unsyncopated form. For example, Phl. *nēk* <nywk>, NP *nik* “gut, schön” has a syncope and derives from the old nominative-accusative (< **nēhki/u* < **nēhaki/u* < **nē’aki/u* < **nāibakah/-am*), while the frequent Paz. *niiak*, *niak*, *nīak*, *niiakh* derives from the old genitive (< **nēāhkē* < **nēhákē* < *nē’ákē* < **najbákahja*). The same happens with the doublette Phl. *ēk* <’ywk> / MMP <yk>, NP *yak*. The former is syncopated (< **ēhki/u* < **ēhaki/u* < **ē’aki/u* < **āiyakah/-am*), the latter is not (< **ēāhkē* < **ēhákē* < **ē’ákē* < **āiyakahja*).

It is also clear that the later one-case system of the thematic nouns arises from a former one with two different cases. One of them clearly goes back to the older genitive. What we do not know is which of these survived into the later one-case system. BACK (1978, p. 35) excludes the possibility of the survival of the genitive for general linguistic reasons, but personal pronouns like *man*, which obviously retain the genitive, invalidate his argument. If HUYSE’s explanation that the “final y” goes back to the old genitive ending is correct, then the generalization of the genitive would seem most likely, since there was a time when this ending still appeared in all nouns. The distribution of this ending in the inscriptions is actually no longer functional, but merely phonetic.

In any case, only formal characteristics allowing us to distinguish between direct and oblique would answer the question. We have already mentioned one characteristic: the incidence of the syncope in all isosyllabic nouns. If the paenultima of one word is syncopated, then it continues the old nominative-accusative. However, when the requirements for a syncope are given but none occurs, then this form is likely to continue the old genitive.⁴ A good number of words show the syncope. Thus the old nominative-accusative presumably survives in them. To this group belong the diminutives in *-ak*⁵ like

- *rēdak* (Phl. *lytk*) < **rajtákakah/-am*
- *andak* (IMP *’ndky*, MMP *’ndk*, Phl. *’ndk’*) < **antákakah/-am*
- *kōdak* (MMP *qwdk*, Phl. *kwtk’*) **kaūtákakah/-am*
- (*h*)*ōzārak* (MMP *hwz’rk*, Phl. *’wc’lk’*)

The same explanation is required for the adjectives in *-uk*

- *tanuk* (MMP *tnwk*, Phl. *tnwk’*) < **tanúkakah/-am*
- *sabuk* (Phl. *spwk’*) < **šrapúkakah/-am*
- *nāzūk* (Phl. *n’cwk’*, NP *nāzok*⁶) < **nāčúkakah/-am*
- *cābuk* (Phl. *c’pwk’*) < **cāpúkakah/-am* (?)

4 The conditions for the syncope are not completely clear. Observe, for instance, forms like *abdom* or *fradom* that cannot be explained easily with these rules.

5 About this formation see KLINGENSCHMITT 2000.

6 A different formation is MMP *n’zwwg* /*nāzūg*/, NP *nāzu* < **nāčāyakah/-am*.

Apart from the syncope, some further formal facts can help to make the distinction clear. For example, the group *-áya-* becomes *ō*, while *-ayá-* remains *awa*. Therefore, we can conclude that the adjectives in *-ōg* < **-áyaka-* go back to the nominative-accusative:

– *mēnōg* (MMP *mynwg*, Phl. *mynwk*) < **manīáyakah/-am*

– *garmōg* (Phl. *glmwk*) < **garmáyakah/-am*

By contrast, forms like *frawardag* (IMP *prwrty*, MMP *prwrdg*, Phl. *plwltk'*) < **frawártakah/-am*.

But there are many forms that appear to be exceptions and seem to go back to the old genitive. They include, for instance, the many nouns with the *-ag* suffix which have no syncope although the conditions for it are given:

<i>ābaxtarag</i>	<i>brahnag</i>	<i>gilag</i>	<i>ōšawārag</i>
<i>abgānag</i>	<i>brahenag</i>	<i>gōnag</i>	<i>pahlawānag</i>
<i>ābilag</i>	<i>bunag</i>	<i>gōšag</i>	<i>pahrag</i>
<i>abyānag</i>	<i>čarag</i>	<i>hamag</i>	<i>pānag</i>
<i>afrošag</i>	<i>čašmag</i>	<i>hōšag</i>	<i>pārag</i>
<i>afsānag</i>	<i>cībag</i>	<i>ispasag</i>	<i>parmānag</i>
<i>ahēnag</i>	<i>cīnag</i>	<i>istārag</i>	<i>pēšēnag</i>
<i>ā'inag</i>	<i>dahmag</i>	<i>išterag</i>	<i>pidēnag</i>
<i>akanārag</i>	<i>dāmag</i>	<i>jamag</i>	<i>pusag</i>
<i>alālag</i>	<i>dānag</i>	<i>jāmag</i>	<i>sāyag</i>
<i>amarag</i>	<i>daxšag</i>	<i>kamāhag</i>	<i>syāwag</i>
<i>ambarag</i>	<i>dēwānag</i>	<i>kumāhag</i>	<i>xānag</i>
<i>anābuhlag</i>	<i>dōšag</i>	<i>kanārag</i>	<i>xāyag</i>
<i>anōšag</i>	<i>dramanag</i>	<i>kūrag</i>	<i>zādag</i>
<i>ārag</i>	<i>ēmag</i>	<i>mardānag</i>	<i>zahag</i>
<i>āstānag</i>	<i>ērag</i>	<i>māyag</i>	<i>zanag</i>
<i>awērag</i>	<i>ēwenag</i>	<i>mayyānag</i>	
<i>bārag</i>	<i>ēwgānag</i>	<i>murdyānag</i>	
<i>brahmag</i>	<i>frōšag</i>	<i>nāmag</i>	

The adjectives with the suffix MP *-ūg*, NP *-u* must also belong to this group. Apparently, these forms go back to the old genitive, e.g. *bānūg* < **bānūkahja*, since the development of the old nominative-accusative should have been **bāng* < **bānūkah/-am*.

All these forms could be explained through the retention of the suffix *-ag* in analogy with the forms in which the conditions for the syncope are not given. In fact, some forms not subjected to any analogical influence, as when the suffix is no longer transparent, show that these forms derive in fact from the old nominative-accusative and that, when the conditions were right, the syncope actually occurred. Two examples were already presented at the beginning of this paper: MP *ēk* < *ywk* < **ēhki/u* < **ēhaki/u* < **ē'aki/u* < **āyakah/-am* and

MP *nēk* <nywk>, NP *nik* “gut, schön” < **nēhki/u* < **nēhaki/u* < **nē’aki/u* < **nāībakah/-am*. Also the derivative *nazdik*, from the old comparative **nazdīah-ka-*, goes back to the old nominative-accusative.

I would like to suggest that forms whose ending is written <-lg> instead of the usual <-lk> equally go back to the OIr. nom./acc.sg. This way of writing these endings indicates that the group /rk/ was changed into /rg/ before the establishment of the orthographic rules of Book Pahlavi, unlike the evolution of /aka/ to /ag/, which occurred later on and thus was not reflected in the orthographic rules of Book Pahlavi. To this group of words belong the following nouns:

- *wistarg* (Phl. *wstlg*) < **uistarakah/-am*
- *tagarg* (MMP *tgrg*, Phl. *tklg*) < **takarakah/-am*
- *sturg* (Phl. *stwlg*, NP *sotorg*) < **stūarakah/-am*

Summing up, among the thematic nouns the generalized form is usually not the genitive, but the nominative-accusative. This was the result of the evolution from Old to Middle Iranian via a system in which there were two different cases: direct (from the old nominative-accusative) and oblique (from the old genitive).

As far as we can tell, the situation is similar for the remainder of the isosyllabic nouns. When the neuter of a consonant stem appears in two different forms, one of them continues the old nominative-accusative and the other the old genitive. For instance, NP *farr* (which also appears in MP in personal names) goes back to the old nominative-accusative (**oarnah*), while MP *farrah* (and also Phl. *xwarrah*) continues the old genitive **oarnahab/-ahja*.⁷ The same pattern applies for *urwāhm* Phl. <’wlw’hm’> (MMP <’wrw’myh’>) < **γūāθma* besides *urwāhman* Phl. <’wlw’hmn’> < **γūāθmanah/-ahja*. The same distribution is also found in MP *zrēh* (MMP *zry(h)*, Phl. *zlyh*⁸) which goes back to the old genitive < **īraiah-ab/-ahja*, while the compound *daryāb* probably reflects a compound **īraiah āpV*.

When the two-case system evolved into a one-case system, it was the direct form that usually survived, continuing the old nominative-accusative. These results fit well with the results in the thematic stems and indirectly confirm our conclusions about them. Examples of OIr. neuter consonant stems continuing the old nominative-accusative are numerous⁹:

7 The exact shape of the genitive protoform of consonantal stems cannot be determined (see below).

8 It should be noted that the Phl. notation *zlyh* could also be read as *zray* <zl’y> (BARTHOLOMAE 1904, 1702). This form may be derived from the old nominative-accusative **īraiah*.

9 The case of the heteroclitics is difficult. The preservation of the last syllable (such as MP *īagar* ~ **īākar*, cf. Av. *yākarə*) suggest a thematization process early on. Consequently, forms like *kišwar* Phl. *kyšwl*, MMP *kyšwr*, *bēwar* Phl. *bywl* MMP *bywr*, *xwar* MMP *xwr*, Phl. *hwl* most probably go back to thematic forms such as **kīšyar-am*/**kīšyārahja*, **bāīyar-am*/**bāīyārahja* and **b(u)yar(am)*/**b(u)yar(ahja)*. That these forms probably

Stems in -s:

<i>bōy</i> (MMP <i>bwy</i> , Phl. <i>bwd</i>) < * <i>báydah</i>	<i>sneh</i> (Phl. <i>snyh</i>) < * <i>snaθiš</i>
<i>drāz</i> (Phl. <i>dl'c</i>) < * <i>drājah</i>	<i>šōy</i> (MMP <i>šwy</i> , Phl. <i>šwd</i>) < * <i>xšáydah</i>
<i>ōš</i> (MMP, Phl. <i>'wš</i>) < * <i>áyšah</i>	<i>tab</i> (Phl. <i>tp</i>) < * <i>tápah</i>
<i>rōy</i> (MMP <i>rwy</i> , Phl. <i>lwd</i>) < * <i>ráydah</i>	<i>tam</i> (MMP, Phl. <i>tm</i>) < * <i>támah</i>
<i>rōz</i> (MMP <i>rwc/z</i> , Phl. <i>lwc</i>) < * <i>ráyčah</i>	<i>war</i> (MMP <i>wr</i> , Phl. <i>wl</i>) < * <i>úarah</i>
<i>sar</i> (MMP <i>sr</i> , Phl. <i>sl</i>) < * <i>čarah</i>	<i>warz</i> (MMP <i>wrz</i> , Phl. <i>wlc</i>) < * <i>úarcab</i>

Stems in -n:

<i>barsom</i> (MMP <i>brswm</i> , Phl. <i>blswm</i>)	<i>cašm</i> (MMP, Phl. <i>cšm</i>) < * <i>cašma</i>
< * <i>barjma</i>	<i>pēm</i> (Phl. <i>pym</i>) < * <i>pažma</i>
<i>carm</i> (MMP <i>crm</i> , Phl. <i>clm</i>) < * <i>carma</i>	<i>rām</i> (MMP <i>r'm</i> , Phl. <i>l'm</i>) < * <i>rāma</i>

Imparissyllabic nouns

While the most important distinction among isosyllabic nouns was between nominative and accusative on the one hand and the genitive on the other, the key distinction among imparissyllabic nouns was between nominative and accusative. While in isosyllabic nouns the loss of the final syllable neutralized the distinction between nominative and accusative – if there was any at all – the loss of the final syllable did not cause nominative and accusative to be confused in the case of the imparissyllables.

Among isosyllabic nouns, the doublettes continue the old nominative-accusative, on the one hand, and the old genitive, on the other. In the case of imparissyllabic nouns we do not have positive evidence that the old genitive ever survived. Usually, one form goes back to the old nominative and the other one to the old accusative. The distribution appears the loanword *ātaxš*, from Av. *ātarš* (nom.sg.), and the inherited word *ādur*, which may only go back to the old accusative *ātrm* (cf. Av. *ātrəm*).¹⁰

continue the thematic nom./acc.sg. rather than the gen.sg. is suggested by *zōr* MMP *zwr*, Phl. *zwl* < **jāyar-am*, since we would expect ***zawar* for the genitive **jāyārahja*.

In other heteroclitics, the *n*-forms of the weak cases seem to have survived. Here too we must presume an earlier process of thematization. The old genitive (like *sahyanh* for *saxwan* < **sahyanam*) or even the accusative plural may well represent the starting point of this process. The latter seems to be the more likely explanation for the doublette *dahān* Phl. *dh'n'* / *dahan* MMP *dhyn*. The latter goes back to **dahanam*, a thematic form built from either gen. *dahanh* or nom./acc.pl. *dahani*. Instead, *dahān* is last derived from the acc.pl. **dahān* (cf. Av. *baēuuqan*, *karšuuqan*), probably via a thematic form **dahānam* or even directly from **dahāni* (cf. OInd. *ābhāni*). Consequently, *saxwan* could also be retaining the old acc.pl. **sahyani*. The fact that some heteroclitics are derived from the old nom./acc.pl. instead of from the nom./acc.sg. is not very surprising, as these plural forms are simply old collective nouns. Therefore, I regard it as very likely that heteroclitics with a final -*r* in MP continue the old nominative-accusative singular, while the forms with final -*n* go back to the old nominative-accusative plural.

Apparently imparisyllabic loanwords were also imported into nominative and accusative, at least in some cases. Most of them are, nevertheless, ambiguous. This is the case for the MP loanword from Av. *āθrauuān*:- the nominative is continued in Phl. *āsrō* 'slwk' (< Av. *āθrauuā*), while *āsrōn* Phl. 'slwn'/ātrōn MMP *trwn* may be derived from the acc.sg. Av. *āθrauuānəm* or, alternatively, from the gen.sg. *aθaurunō* through **asarun*, later syncompated to *asrun*.¹¹

The same ambiguity sometimes appears in inherited words. The form *frāy* MMP *pr'y/fr'y* comes from the old nom.sg.m. **prāiāh* or even from neuter **prāiah*. Actually, *frēh* Phl. <plyh>, NP *fereh* may be a continuation not only of the old acc.sg.m. **prāiāham*, but also of the old gen.sg. **prāiāhah(ia)*.¹² The fact that two different forms of this adjective, which is derived from an old comparative, survived is surprising, as most comparatives survive only in the nominative form, as we will see below.¹³

The analysis of the generalized forms in the one-case system widely provide evidence of the old nominative and accusative, but not of the genitive. Among the imparisyllabic nouns there is not one clear instance in which the surviving form continues the old genitive. Instead, the old nominative or accusative are continued.

Among the masculine and feminine nouns and adjectives in -s only the nominative survives, as becomes obvious when analysing the old comparative adjectives,¹⁴ for instance:

- *meh* (MMP *mhy*, *myh*, Phl. *ms*) < **maθiāh*/**maθiah*
- *weh* (MMP *why*, *wyh*, Phl. *wyh*) < **uahiāh*/**uahiah*
- *keh* (MMP *khy*, *kylh*, Phl. *ks*) < **kaθiāh*/**kaθiah*
- *kem* (Phl. *kym*) < **kambiāh*/**kambiah*

The same is true for other adjectives in -s:

- *pērōz* (MMP *pyrwz*, Phl. *pylwc*) < **pari-ayjāh*
- *xūb* (MMP *xwb*, Phl. *hwp*) < **huyapāh*/**huyapah*
- *°sraw*¹⁵ (Phl. *°slwb*) < **°crauyāh*/**°crauyah*
- *dušman* (MMP *dwšmn*, Phl. *dwšmn*) < **dušmanāh*¹⁶

10 The protoforms of the variants NP *nawe* (MP *nab* Phl. *np*, IMP *npy*) and *nawāde* also exhibit the same distribution: *nab* < **napā* < **népōts* and *nawāde* < **napāt-aka-*, cf. *napātam*. The form *naft* does not go back to the old genitive, but to the adjective **naptiā-*.

11 See CANTERA 2007.

12 In both cases, we must assume a shortening of the first *ā*. The change from *frēh* to NP *fereh* is to be compared with the evolution from *sreš* (< **°craiahām*) to NP *sereh*.

13 Sometimes different forms belong to different dialects, for instance *burz* alongside *buland*. The latter could continue either acc.sg. **brjantam* or a thematic gen.sg. **°bardantabīa* since such formations with the ending *-abīa* attached to the stem of nominative-accusative could be attested in Old Persian (vid. infra).

14 With the exception of *frēh* besides *frāy* discussed above.

15 In proper nouns like *hwsrbw*.

16 It is not easy to determine whether the notations *dwšmn* and *dwšmyn* reflect purely graphical variants of one and the same form derived from **dušmanīuš/-m* (where *y* would be an optional spelling of the vowel *ē*) or whether the forms with *y* continue **dušmanīuš/-m*, while the form *dwšmn* goes back to **dušmanāh*.

The form of the nom.sg. of OIr. perfect active participles in **-uah* is continued in MP adjectives such as *day* (IMP, Phl. *ddw*, MMP *dy*) < **dadūāh*.

Not only the nominative is continued in other stems but also the accusative, which actually prevails. This unquestionably happens in the *n*-stems:

- *aryāmān* / *ērmān* (MMP, 'ry'm'n / Phl. 'ylm'n') < **ariāmānam* / **ariāmānam*
- *asmān* (MMP, Phl. 'sm'n') < **acmānam*
- *darmān* (MMP *drm'n*, Phl. *dln'n*) < **darmānam*
- *dēsman* (MMP *dysm'n*) < **dajmānam*
- *juwān* (MMP *yw'n*, Phl. *ywb'n*) < **juuānam*
- *kārwan* (MMP *k'rw'n*) < **kāraūānam*
- *urwān* / *ruwān* (MMP 'rw'n / *rw'n*, Phl. *lwb'n*) < **ruūānam*
- *zarwan* (MMP *zrw'n*, Phl. *zlw'n*) < **jarūānam*
- *hizwān* / *uzwān* (MMP 'zw'n, Phl. 'wzw'n) < **hiūānam*
- *mēhmān* (MMP *myhm'n*, Phl. *m(')hm'n*)

Some *n*-stems, however, clearly go back to the old nominative. Sure examples are the adjectives with suffix *-ūan* such as the already mentioned *ardā* Phl. 'lt'y, MMP 'rd'w, IMP 'rt'w (< **rtāūā*) and *agrā* MMP 'gr'w, IMP 'yl'dy (< **argāūā*).¹⁷

The distribution in the *nt*-stems is similar. Usually, the nominative disappears and only the accusative survives, as is evident in the productive group of the adjective in *-(ō)mand* and also in the adjectives in *-wand*:

- *arwand* (MMP 'rwnd, Phl. 'lwnd) < **aryāntam*
- *hunarāwand* (MMP *hwnr'w(y)nd*, Phl. *hwnl'wnd*) < **hunarāūāntam*
- *xēšmāwand* (MMP *xyšm'wnd*) < **aišmāūāntam*
- *druwand* (MMP *drwnd*, Phl. *dlwnd*), cf. Av. *druuantəm*¹⁸

The nominative also survives sometimes, for instance, in *farrox* Phl. *plhw'*, MMP *frwx*, *prwx* (< **farrahūā*, nom.sg. of **farrahūant-*) and the dialectal form *burz* Phl. *bwlc* (< **byjā*, nom.sg. of **byjant-*).

Among the imparisyllabic *u*-stems¹⁹ the old accusative usually survives

- *nasā* (MMP *nys'h*, Phl. *ns'y*) < **nacāūam*
- *bāzā* (Phl. *b'c'y*) < **bājāūam*
- *garā/gerā* (Phl. *g(y)l'y*) < **garāūam*²⁰

17 *spul* Phl. *spwl* (< **spjā*) may represent a further example that retains the old nominative. However, in this case, it may also be possible that it is derived from a substantivized adjective **spjā-*, cf. MMP *'spwrygyn* "splenic" (BAILEY 1979, p. 415b).

18 In fact, *druwand* is most likely a loanword from Av. *druuantəm*.

19 For these formations in Iranian see KUIPER 1942, p. 40ff.; NARTEN 1969; TREMBLAY 1996; TREMBLAY 1998; DE VAAN 2000; CANTERA 2007.

20 The original formation behind MP *deb* is not easy to determine. Theoretically, it could be the nominative OP *dahayāuš*, but also the acc. OP *dahayāum* or *dahayāum/dahayum*. Only the acc. OP *dahayāvam* can be excluded. For the problems in the formation of nominative and accusative of Av. *dajhu-*, OP *dahayu-* see CANTERA 2007, pp. 15ff.

The same situation applies to the *r*-stems, with the exception of the kinship nouns.²¹ The old accusative usually survives (like the old inherited word *ādūr* < **ātrym*) and only very rarely the old nominative. The accusative is retained, for instance, in the productive *nomina agentis* in °*tār/dār*. The derivation from the old accusative is also certain for Phl. *xwāhār/xwāhar* < hwh'l/hw'hl>.²²

As mentioned above, the distinction between direct and oblique is still alive and functional for the kinship nouns in MMP, IMP and the oldest Pahlavi translations of the Avesta.²³ The direct goes back to the old nominative (*pid* < **pitā*; *mād* < **mātā*, etc.), but the origin of the oblique is not certain. The oblique plural in -*ān* (< **-ānām*), the doublettes of isosyllabic nouns continuing the old genitive and the oblique of the personal pronouns (like *man* < **mana*) suggest that the oblique of the kinship nouns goes back to the old genitive, but formal arguments speak against this derivation. It is not possible to derive an oblique *pidar* from the old genitive **piθrah* (OP *piça*, Av. *brāθrō*). Therefore, SIMS-WILLIAMS, among others, derives *pidar* etc. from an alternative genitive-ablative **pitara(h)*. But we do not have any evidence for the existence of such a genitive for the kinship nouns, and in West Balochi the old genitive **piθrah*, etc. is preserved to this very day in *piss*, *mās*, *brās*, *zāmās* (KORN 2005, p. 89).

All the attested forms seem to go back directly to the old accusative:

- *pidar* < **pitaram*
- *mādar* < **mādaram*
- *brādar* < **brātaram*
- *xwāhār/xwāhar* < **hyāhāram*²⁴

Given the results obtained with regard to the imparisyllabic nouns in Middle Persian, it seems clear to me that the kinship nouns prove that the oblique is derived from the old accusative and not from the old genitive. But why did the old accusative assume the same role and function among the imparisyllabic nouns as the old genitive among the isosyllabic nouns? The answer to this question requires a short historical outline of nominal morphology from late Old Persian to Middle Persian.

21 The root nouns in -*r* appear in forms that may well represent a continuation of the old accusative: *nar* (MMP *nr*, Phl. *nl*) < **naram*; *dar* (MMP *dr*, Phl. *dl*) < **dyaram*. Nevertheless, an early thematization of the root nouns in -*r* cannot be excluded; for instance, the nom.pl. Av. *naraēca* (V3.8, 18.4). In fact, according to the acc.sg. *stārəm*, nom.pl. *stārō* (OInd. *tārah*) we expect *stār* (cf. Phl. *stārag*) in MP, but the attested form is *star*, although the stem *star-* is not attested.

22 NP *xwāhar* shows a quantity metathesis probably due to the influence of *mādar*, *brādar*. The original form is **hyāhāram* (cf. OInd. *svāsāram*) and is still preserved in Balochi *gwāhār* (KORN 2005, p. 123). It is impossible to decide if the Phl. notation <hwh'l/hw'hl> reflects the old form *xwāhār* or the new one with metathesis *xwāhar*.

23 For this distinction see SIMS-WILLIAMS 1981; SKJAERVO 1983; CANTERA 1999.

24 NP *xwāhar* exhibits a quantity metathesis presumably because of the influence of *mādar*, *brādar*. The original form is **hyāhāram* (cf. OInd. *svāsāram*) and is still preserved in Balochi *gwāhār* (KORN 2005, p. 123). It is impossible to decide if the Phl. notation reflects the old form *xwāhār* or the new one with metathesis *xwāhar*.

Historical outline of Middle Persian nominal inflection

As a consequence of the disappearance of the last syllable in isosyllabic nouns, only the genitive (and perhaps also partially the instrumental) retained a distinct form. All other inflectional forms merged. This lack of formal distinction caused difficulties for the nominative and accusative, while other cases began early to be marked by prepositions. We must remember that – from the inscriptions of Artaxerxes on – the only case form attested in the thematic stems besides the nominative, accusative and genitive is the ablative, and this only in the expression *hacā vispā gastā*, where the ablative is redundant with the preposition *hacā*.

Several indications in the inscriptions of Artaxerxes suggest that nominative and accusative were already being confused at that time²⁵:

A²Sa 3: *imam apadāna ... akunauš*

A²Sa, A2Ha 5 4: *imam apadāna ... akunām*

[cf. *apadānam stūnāya aḡagainam akunauš* A²Hb]

A³Pa5-6: *haya mām artaxšačā xšāyaḏiya akunauš*

There is similar confusion with regard to the feminina in *-ā*:

A³Pa 22-23: *imam ustašanām aḡaganām mām upā mām kartā*

And even between feminina and neuter:

A³Pa 26: *taya mām kartā*

A²Sd: *imām hadiš... akunavām*

As a result of this process, a two-case system emerged for thematic and other isosyllabic nouns in Late OP or Early MP:

direct	<i>apadān</i>
oblique	<i>apadān-ē</i>

Later on, the oblique *-ē* ending was dropped for reasons which in some words seem to be merely phonetic.²⁶ Consequently, the distinction between direct and oblique disappeared in this group of words and only one form, which was identical with the former direct, survived:

direct	<i>apadān</i> > <i>apadān</i>
oblique	<i>apadān-ē</i> > <i>apadān</i>

In the words with no phonetic conditions to explain the loss of the *-ē* ending, the distinction between direct and oblique was also neutralized due to the influence of the words in which the ending had consistently disappeared. Surprisingly enough, the neutralization came about through the generalization of the *-ē* ending also for the direct forms.²⁸ Later on, the *-ē* ending disappeared in all

25 The same applies to A¹I *imam bātugara siyamam viḏiyā karta*, but this inscription is most probably a modern forgery (SCHMITT 2007).

26 The conditions were described by HUYSE 2003.

positions, so that only the $\bar{e}$ -less forms survived also in this group of words, mostly in the form of the old direct:

	1	2	3	4
direct	$*páhn \rightarrow *páhn\bar{e} \quad *páhn\bar{e} > pahn$			
oblique	$*pahán\bar{e} \quad *pahán\bar{e}$			

The evolution for the athematic neuters was similar. The first step was the substitution of the genitive $-ah$ ending by the thematic $-\bar{e}$ ending, a process that may alternatively be explained as hypercharacterization of the old genitive with the $-\bar{e}$ ending.²⁸ As in the thematic stems, the $-\bar{e}$ ending dropped under certain phonetic conditions, so that in a group of words the distinction between direct and oblique was abolished. Consequently, the distinction was neutralized in the remainder of the isosyllabic nouns in which the $-\bar{e}$ ending was also attached to the direct. Finally, the direct form was generalized for the most part and the oblique form disappeared except in some doublettes that continue both forms. The evolution may be represented as follows:

direct	$ra\bar{y}tah > r\bar{o}d \quad r\bar{o}d \rightarrow r\bar{o}d\bar{e} > r\bar{o}d$
oblique	$ra\bar{y}tahah > r\bar{o}dah \rightarrow r\bar{o}dah\bar{e}$

With imparisyllabic nouns the starting point was radically different. The loss of the final syllable did not lead to confusion between nominative and accusative. This clearly emerges from the inscriptions of Artaxerxes. The attested accusatives are always formed correctly²⁹:

asmānam: APa 3, A2Hc 3

framātāram: A1Pa 8, A2Hc 7 [*framātāram*: A3Pa 8]

DHyāum: A3Pa 26

viṣam: A2Hc 20

Apart from the nominative and accusative, only genitive and locative are attested for the imparisyllabic nouns in these late inscriptions. The only attested locative

27 If we do not assume this generalization, we would not be able to explain why the distribution of the final y in IMP is regulated by phonological and not by morpho-syntactical rules. Theoretically, it is also possible that the generalization of the $-\bar{e}$ occurred in all nouns before the $-\bar{e}$ was dropped under the known conditions. Nevertheless, I believe it is more likely that the $-\bar{e}$ was lost before the generalization, as this would explain the neutralization of the difference between direct and oblique starting from a phonological process.

28 As already pointed out, there are indications that the old athematic genitive $-ah$ ending was substituted by $-ah\bar{e}$ already in OP. On the other hand, it is also possible that after the loss of the final syllable the genitive was hypercharacterized and the thematic $-\bar{e}$ ending was attached.

29 The only mistake I would be able to point out is the form *asmānām* (A³Pa 3), but this mistake concerns the ending (that was surely lost or at least weakened in that time) and not the stem. Furthermore, the accusative *xšāyāršām* (from $*xšāyaršan-$) is the only form attested since Xerxes' inscriptions.

is *viθiyā* (A1I). Therefore, we can conclude that only forms of the nominative, accusative and genitive were in productive use.

Determining the shape and extension of the genitive in the athematic nouns is very problematic. In the inscriptions after Artaxerxes, all attested genitives except for the genitive of *mazdā-* (in its variants *mazdāha*, *mazdāhā* and even *mazdahā*) have the thematic ending *-haya*. The old genitive only survives in *dārayavahauš* (A1Pa 16), alongside the frequent variants of the genitive of this proper name with *-haya*. Two questions arise: 1. was the thematic ending generalized in all athematic nouns? and 2. if such was the case, to which stem was the thematic ending added?

The *-ahīa* ending seems to have spread from the thematic nouns to the athematic ones. This emerges from the fact that starting with the inscriptions of Artaxerxes only the *-ahīa* ending seems to have been productive and that the final *y* in IMP was attached to all thematic and athematic nouns. The beginning of this process can be dated quite early, as it also appears in the form *tunuṽatahaya*/*tunuṽa*"*tabaya* in DNb9. But it is impossible to know how far the ending **-ahīa* spread in Old Persian, because (apart from the mentioned forms of the genitive of *mazdā-* and *dārayavahu-*) all other attested genitives are proper names in genealogical lists. These lists present syntactic difficulties because of the frequent use of the nominative instead of the genitive. The few athematic genitives attested alongside *dārayavahauš* (A1Pa 16) have the ending *-haya*:

- *dārayavaušahayā* [*dārayavašahayā*]
- *xšayāršahayā* [*xšayārcahayā*], *xšāyaršāhaya*

Since these forms are built by attaching the ending *-haya* to the nominative, we cannot exclude that they are *ad hoc* formations of the late Achaemenid scribes. The fact that some genitives, like those of the kinship nouns, have survived for a long time prevents us from assuming a very early and widespread generalization of the *-ahīa* ending.

At a certain time the old athematic genitive which had a different stem from the nominative and accusative and which was formed with the ending *-a(h)* or *-ahīa*, was substituted by a new one, more akin to the rest of the paradigm. The old, differentiated genitive stem was abandoned and a new genitive was formed on the basis of the accusative stem in the masculine and feminine nouns, and of the nominative-accusative in the neuter ones, as has been proposed for the isosyllabic neuter stems: the old genitive *rōdah* < **rōdaha(h)* / **rōdahē* was replaced by the gen. **rōdē*.

Before the formation of the new genitive, there was a three-case system for the imparisyllabic nouns in which every case was represented by a different stem:

nom.	<i>*pitā</i> > <i>pid</i>
acc.	<i>*pitaram</i> > <i>pidar</i>
gen./obl.	<i>*piθrah</i> > <i>*pis</i>

Once the old genitive was at least partially substituted by a new one by attaching the *-abja/-ē* ending to the accusative stem, the result was also a three-case system, but with a more paradigmatic genitive:

nom.	<i>pid</i>
acc.	<i>pídar</i>
gen.	<i>*pídarē</i>

Due to the influence of the isosyllabic nouns, the *-ē* ending extended to the accusative and probably also to the nominative:

nom.	<i>*pid(ē)</i>
acc.	<i>*pídarē</i>
gen.	<i>*pídarē</i>

Hence a two-case system, similar to that of the imparisyllabic nouns, emerged from a three-case system. The main difference was that, while the old accusative disappeared early on in the isosyllabic nouns and the oblique retained the old genitive, the oblique continues the old accusative in the imparisyllabic nouns³⁰. The derivation of the oblique of imparisyllabic nouns from the old accusative allows us to explain a morpho-syntactic peculiarity of the distribution between direct and oblique among the kinship nouns that SIMS-WILLIAMS and SKJAERVØ affirmed for Manichaean and inscriptional Middle Persian: the fact that the direct object was sometimes expressed with the direct and sometimes with the oblique, without a recognizable reason. This fact is easy to understand in view of our results: among the imparisyllabic nouns, the direct object was naturally represented by the oblique, since it continues the old accusative; however, it was represented by the direct among the isosyllabic nouns, since both the old nominative and the old accusative had merged. Of course, this distribution (direct object = oblique [= old accusative] for the imparisyllabic nouns and direct object = direct [= old nom./acc.] for the isosyllabic nouns) was not easy to maintain. As a result direct and oblique were used indistinctively for the direct object.

This functional peculiarity of direct and oblique is, in fact, one of the most obvious indications of the existence of two different inflectional systems: one for the isosyllabic nouns and another for the imparisyllabic ones. Further evidence is provided by the different stem formations for the isosyllabic nouns (only a undifferentiated nominative-accusative and differentiated genitive survive) and for the imparisyllabic nouns (the nominative and accusative survive with distinctive function, and there is no sure evidence of the survival of the genitive), as I hope to have demonstrated.

30 Or it is formally identical with the old accusative, because it could also be a continuation of the new genitive created by attaching *-ē* to the accusative stem. In any case, the accusative stem was the basis for the oblique.

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